

Offprint from:

Diachrony in Biblical Hebrew

Edited by

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Winona Lake, Indiana
EISENBRAUNS
2012

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Printed in the United States of America.

www.eisenbrauns.com

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Diachrony in biblical Hebrew / edited by Cynthia L. Miller-Naudé and Ziony Zevit.
p. cm. — (Linguistic studies in ancient West Semitic ; 8)

Includes bibliographical references and indexes.

ISBN 978-1-57506-253-2 (hardback : alk. paper)

1. Hebrew language—Grammar. 2. Bible O.T.—Language, style.
3. Linguistic change. I. Miller, Cynthia L. (Cynthia Lynn), 1957– II. Zevit,
Ziony.

PJ4556.D485 2012

492.4'5—dc23

2012028645

The paper used in this publication meets the minimum requirements of the American National Standard for Information Sciences—Permanence of Paper for Printed Library Materials. ANSI Z39.48-1984.®™

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The Evolution of Literary Hebrew in Biblical Times

The Evidence of Pseudoclassicisms

JAN JOOSTEN

1. Introduction

Historical research on Biblical Hebrew operates, as does most research in the humanities (and perhaps in the natural sciences as well), in the framework of a “grand narrative.” One might call it a paradigm or, more simply, a working hypothesis: a set of suppositions permitting scholars to make sense of a great variety of disparate data. For almost 200 years, reckoning from the publication of Gesenius’ *Geschichte der hebräischen Sprache und Schrift* in 1815, the grand narrative of knowledgeable Hebraists has been as follows:

- Most of the Hebrew Bible—including the bulk of the Pentateuch and Former Prophets—was written in the monarchic era (between the tenth and the sixth centuries B.C.E.) in the official literary language practiced at the court and in the temple of the state of Judah.
- A sizable corpus, however, containing notably the books of Ezra–Nehemiah, Chronicles, Esther, Daniel, and Qoheleth came into being only after the Babylonian Exile.
- The Classical Hebrew (CBH) of the older, preexilic books differs from the Late Biblical Hebrew (LBH) of the postexilic books, with the differences being due mostly to diachronic development.
- A corollary of this theory is that biblical texts may in principle be dated, approximately, on the basis of their language. For instance, although tradition attributes Qoheleth and Daniel to the tenth and the sixth centuries, respectively, the language of these books shows that they were written after the exile.

Of course, many important questions are left open in this scheme. Books that are basically preexilic may have been edited, supplemented, or partially rewritten in later times. There may be more varieties of Hebrew than just classical and late: dialectal subtypes, professional jargon, higher and lower stylistic registers. A transitional period may have to be postulated between pre- and

postexilic Hebrew. Poetic texts will be hard to classify, because poets exploit a much wider range of expressions than is usual in prose. Some old poems may reflect the Hebrew language of the premonarchic period. Grand narratives, however, are made to incorporate these sorts of open questions. They provide an initial framework within which scientific observations can meaningfully be debated.

Grand narratives do not fall from the clear sky. They are not arbitrary constructs established by mere convention. In the present case, the adoption of the basic scheme of preexilic versus postexilic Hebrew owed much to the authority and obvious competence of Wilhelm Gesenius (Joosten forthcoming). When he published his *Geschichte*, he was only 29 years old, but by this tender age he had already authored both a dictionary and a grammar of Biblical Hebrew—he could know. His dictionary and grammar contained many observations confirming the approach. The theory also accorded with the general state of biblical studies at the beginning of the nineteenth century. De Wette had recently laid the foundation for a critical approach to the dating of biblical texts: Deuteronomy, introducing the idea of cult centralization, belonged to the time of Josiah, roughly the seventh century B.C.E.; writings familiar with the idea of cult centralization were later than Deuteronomy; while writings unfamiliar with this idea were earlier (De Wette 1805). Gesenius's scheme received a major boost when Hebrew inscriptions from the monarchic period came to light. The language of these inscriptions turned out to conform closely to the Hebrew of the biblical texts dated to the earlier period.¹ Later generations of Hebraists adopted the approach because in their opinion it continued to function as a valuable reference point for their own research.

Dominant narratives are not proven facts, however. They are not observable. They are therefore open to challenge. A recent challenge to the Hebraists' scheme was developed first by Ernst-Axel Knauf and Philip Davies and later by Ian Young, Robert Rezetko, and Martin Ehrensivärd and some others. Roughly, what these scholars argue is that the language considered to be pre-exilic in the earlier approach is in reality a dialect, or style-form, that could freely be selected by authors writing in different periods, including the post-exilic period.² Claims of this sort do more than tweak the related elements of a working hypothesis. They are meant to shatter the grand narrative to pieces. According to a recent study by Young illustrating the new approach, Classical (or Standard, or Early) Biblical Hebrew is found not only in the Pentateuch and Former Prophets but also in Haggai and Zechariah, which belong to the

1. When the Siloam inscription—the first Judean inscription from biblical times to be discovered—came to light in 1880, scholars were happy to observe that its language was close to preexilic Hebrew. Note the opinion of Driver (1912: x): “The Hebrew is as idiomatic and flowing as a passage from the Old Testament.” Similarly Cooke (1903: 16): “The style is pure and idiomatic, and reads like a good prose passage out of the O.T.”

2. For the recent debate, see the articles in Young 2003.

early Persian period, and in the Qumran *Pesher Habakkuk* from the Hellenistic period (Young 2008). The upshot is that linguistic analysis can contribute nothing to the dating of biblical texts.

Several biblical scholars have been happy to embrace this new approach, which is congenial to their own impression of the date of biblical literature (Ben Zvi 2010). Hebraists, however, have not found the theory apposite. This could be due to the natural and well-documented tendency of scholars to cling to old ideas, particularly ideas to which they committed themselves in writing.³ But it is equally possible that the challenge is ill founded. The issue can be resolved only by a renewed analysis of the facts. In this essay, I contribute to this renewed analysis by drawing attention to one particular aspect of Hebrew texts dated by common consent to the Persian period or later.

2. Matching up Arguments and Evidence

Among Hebrew writings for which a postexilic date is not controversial, some texts conform to what one expects in the LBH corpus: they use Persian loanwords, lexical and grammatical Aramaisms, and other elements unattested in CBH; others, however, remain closer to CBH usage. The variation between texts diverging from CBH and texts conforming to it arises at least in part because of stylistic choices made by the authors. This is not a new insight, but it is certainly true.⁴ Young bases his demonstration on observations about the language of *Pesher Habakkuk*, mostly in the area of vocabulary, but also in the area of grammar (Young 2008). Although the method is perhaps skewed somewhat toward numbering—linguistic features ought to be weighed as much as counted—Young develops a fruitful avenue of research. The same method could be applied to other Qumran texts, to Ben Sira, and to the late books of the Hebrew Bible. It would be interesting to know which writings are relatively more similar to CBH and which works use other modes of expression more freely, and to ask why the difference arises.

The successful demonstration of this point does very little, however, to counter the idea that linguistic differences can be used to date an ancient Hebrew text. *Pesher Habakkuk* may be written in a language that strongly resembles Classical Biblical Hebrew, but this quality does not impede the diachronic approach. If *Pesher Habakkuk* were an undated text, impossible to date on the strength of its contents, a Hebraist trained in historical linguistics would have little trouble establishing its relatively late date.⁵ The central word of

3. This insight is often attributed to Thomas Kuhn, but it was already well known to Max Planck: "Eine neue wissenschaftliche Wahrheit pflegt sich nicht in der Weise durchzusetzen, daß ihre Gegner überzeugt werden und sich als belehrt erklären, sondern vielmehr dadurch, daß ihre Gegner allmählich aussterben und daß die heranwachsende Generation von vornherein mit der Wahrheit vertraut geworden ist" (Plank 1948: 2).

4. See, for example, Joosten 1999 and the literature gathered there.

5. When medieval manuscripts of the *Damascus Document* were discovered in the Cairo Geniza, at the end of the nineteenth century, some scholars proposed dating the writing to

Pesher Habakkuk, the Hebrew word פֶּשֶׁר itself, is a late loanword that reached Hebrew through Aramaic. Avi Hurvitz has argued that four criteria need to be observed in order to argue for the lateness of a given text (Hurvitz 1972):

1. *Distribution*: elements of the text to be dated should align with late books exclusively, being unattested in the CBH corpus.
2. *Extrabiblical confirmation*: extrabiblical parallels in Hebrew and other languages, especially Aramaic, can strengthen the diachronic validity of certain features.
3. *Opposition*: the lateness of a given element can be confirmed if an exact equivalent can be identified in the CBH corpus.
4. *Accumulation*: a late text should manifest an accumulation of late linguistic features.

The word פֶּשֶׁר answers to all these criteria:⁶

1. In Biblical Hebrew, it is attested only in Qoh 8:1.
2. It is also found 34 times in the Aramaic of Daniel.⁷
3. In the CBH corpus, other words are used to express the meaning 'interpretation'.⁸
4. The word פֶּשֶׁר occurs dozens of times throughout 1QpHab.

This feature alone (use of the word פֶּשֶׁר) would suffice to indicate that the text is postexilic. In addition, the pesher contains the late Persian loanword מְסֵר 'mystery', and the classical word קָן is used in the late sense of 'period'.⁹ Case closed.

It all comes down to what one wants to demonstrate. Due to an interest in language typology, one may undertake to show that "Late Biblical Hebrew" is not a homogenous state of language. There are important linguistic differences among the various books that compose the LBH corpus.¹⁰ To describe the

the Middle Ages. Solomon Schechter, the editor of the text, dated it to the Second Temple period, invoking among other things the evidence of its language:

The language of the ms is for the most part pure Biblical Hebrew. The first three pages rise even to the dignity of Scriptural poetry, though a good deal of it is obscured by the unfortunate condition in which the text is at present. But there are in it terms and expressions which occur only in the Mishna or even only in the Rabbinic literature dating from the first centuries of the Middle Ages. (Schechter 1910: xi)

6. The fourth criterion is normally taken to refer to the accumulation of different features, not the repeated attestation of one word. The word פֶּשֶׁר occurs so often in 1QpHab, however, and is so central to the argument that it can hardly be explained as a gloss or a word that entered the writing in the course of later revision.

7. The word is of Akkadian origin but almost certainly reached Hebrew through the medium of Aramaic.

8. For the CBH equivalents of פֶּשֶׁר, see Gen 40:12, 18; and Judg 7:15.

9. Note 1QpHab 7:2: גַּמֵּר הַקָּץ 'the end of the period'.

10. This is not something that has escaped scholarly notice: in a plenary debate on the diachronic approach of Biblical Hebrew at the 14th World Congress of Jewish Studies in

diversity among the late biblical books more precisely is worthwhile. It may lead to interesting new results.

If, however, the aim is to date undated texts, other considerations come into play. Mainstream Hebraists are not in the least perturbed by the use of CBH features in *Pesher Habakkuk* or other late writings. Authors of the Persian and Hellenistic periods knew much of the classical literature intimately and wished to situate their own writing in continuity with it. They made a conscious effort to model their literary production on the earlier texts (Greenfield and Naveh 1984: 120–22). Therefore, their use of what appears to be classical Hebrew does not affect the question of date. For dating purposes, only their use of post-classical elements, such as פֶּשֶׁר or רַ, is significant.

The viability of the approach hinges in this case on the notion of imitation, or artificial continuation. This is indeed an important postulate of Hebrew studies: after the exile, when some of the writings that would later become part of the Bible had acquired a measure of authority, authors wrote religious literature in a style that intended to remain close to the earlier texts.¹¹ In the remainder of this essay, I point to evidence showing that this postulate is justified. Later authors did indeed imitate Classical Hebrew, which they knew from studying old texts. The result, however, was not always felicitous. The later authors did not fully master the classical language but “tripped up” in small details. Even the late books with the most instances of classicizing language are not classical but pseudoclassical.

3. Pseudoclassicism in *Pesher Habakkuk*:

Confusion of Literary Registers

The *Pesher Habakkuk* selected by Young is as good a place to begin as any. Many words and expressions that appear in the commentary part of this writing are biblical but unattested in the core corpus of Late Biblical Hebrew. But the use of classical elements does not mean the Hebrew itself is classical. Even where the vocabulary is the same, the usage is subtly different.

One of the words classified as “Early Biblical Hebrew” by Young is the noun עֲרִיץ ‘violent (?)’ in 1QpHab 2:6. The word appears 20 times in the biblical corpus but never in LBH. The mere use of the word, however, does not imply that the pesher is written in “Early” BH. In the Bible, עֲרִיץ is a poetic word that is found in Psalms, Job, Proverbs, Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel, exclusively in poetic passages:¹²

2005, David Talshir challenged the scholars in the room to name one feature that is found in all the core LBH books but in no classical text; no one took up the challenge.

11. “Post-exilic texts seem to reflect the more or less artificial employment of the pre-exilic ‘classical’ literary language, which no longer existed as a spoken medium” (Elwolde 2006: 136).

12. The existence of poetic words in Biblical Hebrew was already well known to Gesenius (1815: 22). Living languages also tend to use certain words in poetry only: in French,

- (1) וּפְקַדְתִּי עַל־תְּבִל רָעָה וְעַל־רָשָׁעִים עֲוֹנָם
וְהִשְׁבַּתִּי גֵאוֹן זָדִים וְגֵאוֹת עֲרִיצִים אֲשָׁפִיל
I will punish the world for its evil, / and the wicked for their iniquity;
I will put an end to the pride of the arrogant, / and lay low the insolence of *tyrants*. (Isa 13:11)

In *Pesher Habakkuk*, however, the usage is not poetic:

- (2) וְכֵן פֶּשֶׁר הַדָּבָר [עַל הַבּוֹרָאִים לְאַחֲרִית אֵל
הַיָּמִים. הֵמָּה עֲרִיצֵי הַבָּרָא] יֵית אֲשֶׁר לֹא יֵאֱמִינוּ
בְּשׁוֹמֵעַם אֶת כּוֹל הַבְּאִרְתָּ [עַל] הַדּוֹר הָאַחֲרוֹן מִפִּי
The interpretation of the word [concerns the traitors] in the last days.
They are the violator[s of the coven]ant who will not believe when
they hear all that is going [to happen t]o the last generation.
(1QpHab 2:5–7)

The use of a poetic word in a prosaic context seems to reflect artificial reuse. The Qumran writers found עֲרִיצ in Scripture and decided to use it in their own writings but failed to pay attention to the word's literary register.

If the use of עֲרִיצ were an isolated case, it could be brushed off as an accident. But there are several other examples of words and forms that appear only in poetry in the biblical texts but turn up in prose in the pesher. The noun הוֹן 'abundance, wealth' is found 26 times in the Bible, always in poetical contexts, with a strong concentration in wisdom literature. In the pesher, as in Qumran Hebrew generally, הוֹן is used in prosaic discourse and means simply 'money'.¹³ Other poetic features of Biblical Hebrew that are recycled in the pesher's prose are the verb פָּעַל 'to do' (1QpHab 8:13; 12:8) and the "archaic" form לָמוּ 'for them' (1QpHab 5:6).

The confusion of levels of style typifies language use that is non-native. While it is relatively easy to study the vocabulary and grammar of a foreign language, it is much harder to develop a feel for register. A foreigner may write nearly perfect English, yet the stilted or pedantic quality of his or her style may give him or her away. Similarly, the use of poetic words in nonpoetic contexts shows that Biblical Hebrew was not a native idiom of the Qumran authors but an acquired language. The slight misuse of CBH elements in *Pesher Habakkuk* indicates, as surely as do the postclassical elements, the relatively late date of the composition.

words such as *aquilon* for the north wind, *couche* in the meaning 'bed', and *épancher* 'to pour' are used only in poetry or in high-flown prose.

13. The word alternates with nonbiblical מָמוֹן in a way that suggests that the latter was the normal word for 'money' while הוֹן was a more prestigious synonym (see, for example, 1QS 6:2 and 19).

4. Semantic Pseudoclassicisms in Qumran Hebrew

The pseudoclassical nature of Qumran Hebrew can also be demonstrated from semantics. Some CBH words and expressions are used in later writings with a meaning that reflects the interpretation of old texts, not the natural continuity of the language. An interesting example, not attested in *Pesher Habakkuk* but in the *Damascus Document*, is the verb אִוֵּת (Joosten 2003). Close study of the contexts where it occurs, in Gen 34:15, 22, 23; and 2 Kgs 12:9, indicates that the verb means 'to consent' in the Bible.¹⁴ In the *Damascus Document*, however, the verb should be translated 'to associate with, to pool resources':

(3) אֵל {יֵת} יִאוֹת אִישׁ עֲמוֹ בְּהוֹן וּבַעֲבוּדָה

No one should *associate* with (the one who is slack in the fulfillment of the instructions of the upright) in wealth or work. (CD 20:7)¹⁵

The divergence between biblical and Qumranic usage most likely indicates that the original meaning of the verb, 'to consent', was forgotten in later times. The new meaning, 'to associate with', arose from the interpretation of Genesis 34, a chapter where the notion of sharing economic resources plays an important part. The interpretation underlying the Qumranic use of the verb אִוֵּת also surfaces in the targums on the Pentateuch. In *Tg. Neofiti* and in a Geniza fragment, the verb is translated אֶתְעַרַּב, lit., 'to intermingle' and thence 'to share, to associate with'. This same verb is used in the *Rule of the Community* (1QS) in a close parallel to the passage from the *Damascus Document* (CD) quoted above:

(4) וְלֹא יִתְעַרַּב אִישׁ מֵאֲנָשֵׁי הַקֹּדֶשׁ בְּהוֹנוֹ וְעַם עֲצָתוֹ לְכוֹל דָּבָר

None of the men of holiness should associate with his goods (that is, the goods of the one who breaks a word of the law of Moses) or his advice on any matter. (1QS 8:23)¹⁶

The Qumran authors borrowed the verb אִוֵּת from Scripture, but they used it in a sense that was arrived at secondarily on the basis of interpretation. At first sight, the use of the verb in CD 20:7 may create the impression that the text is written in pure Classical Hebrew. But closer analysis indicates that this is not so. The language is not classical but pseudoclassical.

Several other pseudoclassicisms have been uncovered in the course of the linguistic analysis of the scrolls (Joosten 1999; Kister 2009):

14. A different reading of the evidence is proposed by Kottsieper 2010; see, however, Kister 2009: 568.

15. The verb also appears in a fragment of the *Damascus Document* discovered at Qumran: 4Q266 frg. 1 1:15.

16. See also 1QS 9:8.

- שחת 'pit' is used with the meaning 'perdition' based on the root שחת 'to destroy' (Wernberg-Møller 1957: 81);
- מעוז 'refuge' (from עוז) is used with the meaning 'strength' on the root עוז 'to be strong' (for example, 1QH^a 16:23–24);
- אפעה 'serpent' is used with the meaning 'wickedness', from contextual exegesis (Joosten 1999: 150–51).

All these "biblical" words are used in the scrolls with new meanings based on etymological or contextual exegesis. The phenomenon shows that the Qumran writings were composed in a period far removed from the original setting of the biblical books, the language of which they borrowed.

5. Pseudoclassicisms in Late Biblical Hebrew

The reuse of archaic expressions of the type illustrated is characteristic of Qumran Hebrew, but it is not exclusive to this literature. Instances of the phenomenon are found sporadically in the late biblical books as well.

An interesting example is the use of the idiomatic expression 'to fill one's hand' (את יד + X מלא). In the Pentateuch and Former Prophets, this expression means 'to ordain to a sacred office' or something very similar:

- (5) וְהָאִישׁ מִיכָה לוֹ בֵּית אֱלֹהִים וַיַּעַשׂ אֶפֶוד וְתַרְפִּים
וַיִּמְלֵא אֶת־יָד אֶחָד מִבָּנָיו וַיְהִי־לוֹ לְכֹהֵן

This man Micah had a shrine, and he made an ephod and teraphim, and *installed* one of his sons, who became his priest. (Judg 17:5)¹⁷

In Ezek 43:26, the expression refers to the consecration of an altar. The etymology of the meaning 'to ordain' is obscure.

In addition, the expression is attested three times in Chronicles. Modern translations and dictionaries tend to treat the LBH passages the same way as the others. Attention to the context shows, however, that this is problematic (Paran 1989: 283–84; Joosten 1999:152–53). Two of the Chronicles passages have nothing whatsoever to do with consecration or induction to a priestly office. In 1 Chr 29:5, David appeals to the people to give gold, silver, and precious stones for the building of the temple. After having enumerated all he is willing to donate himself, he goes on to say:

- (6) וּמִי מִתְנַדֵּב לְמִלְאוֹת יָדוֹ הַיּוֹם לַיהוָה
Who, then, will offer willingly, *filling their hands* today to the LORD?
(1 Chr 29:5b)

The NRSV has rendered this 'Who then will offer willingly, *consecrating themselves* . . .', but there is no contextual warrant for this translation. The Israelites who contribute to the building of the temple are not priests, nor are they trying

17. See also Exod 28:41; 29:9, 29, 33, 35; Lev 8:33; 16:32; 21:10; Num 3:3; Judg 17:12; 1 Kgs 13:33.

to become priests. The passage is concerned with donations. The expression 'to fill their hand' is a figure of speech implying generosity. One might render the half verse: 'Who then will offer willingly, *filling his hands* today with gifts for the Lord?' Similarly, the subject matter in 2 Chr 29:31 is giving, not ordination.

In the third passage, the notion of ordination does come up, but it is doubtful whether the idiom 'to fill the hand' expresses it:¹⁸

- (7) הלא הדחתם את־כהני יהוה את־בני אהרן והלויים ותעשו לכם
כהנים כעמי הארצות כל־הבא למלא ידו בפר בן־בקר ואילם
שבִּעָה ויהי כהן ללא אלהים

Have you not driven out the priests of the LORD, the descendants of Aaron, and the Levites, and made priests for yourselves like the peoples of other lands? Whoever comes, *filling his hand* with a young bull or seven rams, will be a priest of what are no gods. (2 Chr 13:9)

As the reference to the 'young bull or seven rams' shows, the 'filling of the hand' concerns the gift that an apostate Israelite brings in order to be inducted into the priesthood. Those who 'fill their hand' with a big enough gift are ordained as priests. The gift is a prerequisite of the ordination, not the ordination itself. None of the passages in the Pentateuch or Former Prophets mentions this sort of gift, and none seems to be implied there.

We may conclude that the meaning of the expression 'to fill the hand' is different in Classical BH and Late BH.¹⁹ While in CBH it means 'to ordain to a priestly office', in LBH it means 'to bring an offering'. The latter meaning probably reflects interpretation on the basis of the component parts. By the time of the Chronicler, the old idiomatic expression had fallen into disuse and its global meaning had been forgotten, at least by some readers of the Hebrew Scriptures.²⁰

18. 2 Chr 13:9 is loosely parallel to 1 Kgs 13:33, where the idiomatic expression is used in the classical way. It appears, however, that the Chronicler has here freely rewritten his source text, thus enabling him to use the expression with the pseudoclassical meaning.

19. Young and Rezetko (2008: 106–9) argue, on the basis of secondary literature, that the use in Chronicles is the same as in the CBH corpus. Attentive study of the Hebrew passages shows that this is not so.

20. Similar reanalysis of old idiomatic expressions occurs frequently in our own time. In French, the expression *faire long feu* (literally 'to make long fire') derives from the practice of lighting a canon: if the fire was "long," the shot didn't go off. Originally the expression meant 'to fail'. In modern times, however, the practice of lighting canons has fallen out of use, and the idea underlying the expression is no longer understood. *Faire long feu* is often used in the meaning 'to succeed over a long period of time', usually with a negation: *ce projet ne fera pas long feu* ('that project will fail quickly'). In English, expressions such as "to wet (instead of 'to whet') one's appetite" and "the point is mute (instead of 'moot')" also show that old idiomatic expressions are poorly understood (although I cannot testify to their being used with a different meaning).

The claim that the Chronicler's use of the expression rests on exegesis can be strengthened by a comparison with the targums. In the targums, beginning with *Tg. Onqelos* to the Pentateuch, the expression 'to fill the hand' is systematically rendered 'to bring an offering' (קרב קרבנא). The end of the verse from Judg 17:5 quoted above is translated in *Tg. Jonathan*:

- (8) וקריב ית קרבן חד מבנוהי והוה ליה לכהין
He brought the offering of one of his sons, who became his priest.

While the Hebrew text makes no reference to an offering, the targum introduces this notion on the basis of the idiomatic expression. The targum indicates that the interpretation known to the Chronicler enjoyed wider currency among learned Jews during the Second Temple period. The Chronicler not only knew this interpretation but went so far as to revive the ancient expression in his own writing—with the new meaning.

Pseudoclassicisms are less frequent in the LBH corpus than in the Qumran scrolls, but they are not rare. Several other examples have been identified in Chronicles, Nehemiah, and Daniel (Joosten 1999). They show that later authors studied earlier texts diligently and tried to link up with the earlier language and style in their own writing. They also show that, by the time the late biblical books were composed, CBH had already become a "dead language" to a certain extent.

6. Conclusion

In a general essay on the dating of biblical literature by linguistic means, Ron Hendel envisions the possibility of a work written in flawless CBH during the Persian period (Hendel 2005: 110). Through perfect imitation, a late author would be able to create a work, the postexilic date of which would be impossible to detect. Although this eventuality cannot be excluded, the study of pseudoclassicisms shows how improbable it is. Even authors who strongly manifest their intention to stick to classical models occasionally go astray. This is not just a matter of including one or two modern expressions, such as the word פֶּשֶׁר. Even when words and forms were taken straight from earlier texts, the way they were used was not always in accord with classical usage.

The ostensible linguistic similarity between CBH and texts of the Second Temple period such as Chronicles or *Pesher Habakkuk* is deceptive. Although the words are the same, the subtle interplay between them is not. In some instances, the differences may be due to natural evolution of the language. In other instances, some of which have been discussed here, the changes do not reflect organic development but artificial recycling. The presence of pseudoclassicisms in the Hebrew literature of the Second Temple period strongly favors the chronological approach developed by Wilhelm Gesenius and continued in our times by Avi Hurvitz and others.

* * *

Recent revisionist proposals would take Hebrew studies back to premodern times, when Biblical Hebrew was regarded as a synchronic—or pan-chronic—whole, unyielding to historical analysis. This is not a paradigm shift most Hebraists would care to embrace.

A more serious problem is the growing distance between Hebrew linguistics and biblical studies. The diachronic markers established with much acumen and sophistication by Hebraists play little or no part in the equally subtle game of dating biblical texts as practiced by exegetes. Attacks on the documentary hypothesis in the late 1970s have inaugurated a period in which it has become commonplace to date substantial parts of the Pentateuch to the Persian period or later. To the mainstream Hebrew linguist, these proposals are difficult, or even absurd. The language of, say, Genesis 15 is different from that of Ezra–Nehemiah in a way that makes it almost impossible to imagine that the two texts come from the same general period. On this point, a great deal of work remains to be done. Linguists should sharpen their criteria, and exegetes should reflect more on their methodology. But mostly what is called for is more dialogue between the two groups.

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